revolutionary murders? He had none. So how could Irwin proceed to suspend the sentence on a promise which was without foundation and stood unsubstantiated? He could not. To be effective, Gandhi had to ask not for a ‘suspension of sentence’ but an outright commutation as he had done in the other cases of prisoner release. This he did not do.

In the end Gandhi did not escape the harsh judgement of providence. While many have praised his efforts, many others have not. Juneja writes, ‘Gandhi alone could have intervened effectively to save Bhagat Singh’s life. He did not, till the very last.’ In fact, he is clear that ‘Gandhi was not candid . . . on saving Bhagat Singh’s life’.[20] If this is so, then it is hardly surprising because Gandhi himself mockingly wrote that ‘. . . I want the greater bravery . . . of the meek, the gentle and the non-violent, the bravery that will mount the gallows without injuring, or harbouring any thoughts of injury to a single soul’.[21] This is so unrealistic that it is ludicrous. Why on earth would anyone have to mount the gallows if they had not even harboured so much as a thought of injuring a soul? The Mahatma in his sanctimoniousness does not deign to explain. This is Indian mysticism pure and simple which bears no relevance to the reality on the ground where people hang from the gallows for the injury they have caused. No one in the real world hangs for the sin of non-injury to a single soul. Gurdev Singh Deol had little doubt that Gandhi had no expectation of commutation of death, and did not want one, if what he had said to Irwin was that the boys could be hanged before the Karachi session but not after it.[22] After the boys were indeed hanged, Gandhi released a statement in *The Tribune* the next day on 24 March 1931. He described Bhagat Singh as if he was a person of only transient and fleeting memory unknown to him, someone quite distant from his own life as a crusader for India’s freedom. Gandhi’s words were that, ‘[t]here never has been, within living memory, so much romance round any life as has surrounded that of Bhagat Singh’, even as he struggled to remember how ‘. . . I must have seen him as a student while at Lahore many times’, but that ‘I cannot recall Bhagat Singh’s features’. Such was his fading recollection of him even as the young Bhagat Singh had bravely mounted the gallows with Sukhdev and Rajguru. He could not have known